

STAGE FIFTEEN • BUSINESS & ORGANIZATIONAL ACUMEN

FIRSTS

Business & Organizational Acumen

SESSION 1

Understanding How Organizations Work

FIRSTS S1-S9

Business Model Awareness

- Product $\neq$ revenue mechanism
- Three sentences: create, deliver, capture value
- Foundation for the whole stage

Organizational Structure Awareness

- Beyond your own immediate team
- Helps navigate decisions and escalations
- Formal chart $\neq$ how decisions really get made

Department Function Mapping

- Names are often misleading guides
- Confirm with a real conversation
- Know who to actually approach

Revenue Model Awareness

- Not all revenue streams are equal
- Shapes what genuinely matters to the org
- Sets up Cost Structure next

Cost Structure Awareness

- The visible cost isn't always the largest
- Real financial impact, not just revenue potential
- The other half of the P&L picture

Budget Awareness

- Timing changes what's realistically approvable
- Learn the real cycle, not the assumed one
- Immediately usable, practical knowledge

Profit & Loss Awareness

- Revenue + costs come together here
- “Profit” is concrete, not abstract
- Growing revenue $\neq$ genuinely profitable

Business KPI Awareness

- What leadership actually measures as success
- Confirm it — don't assume it
- Sets up Operational Metrics next

Operational Metrics Exercise

- Granular beats high-level alone
- The actual tracked metric, not general impression
- Closes the section: org-wide down to one process

SESSION 2

Analyzing the Business

FIRSTS S10-S19

Stakeholder Mapping Exercise

- Internal AND external
- External stakeholders are the ones most often missed
- Anticipate concerns, build real support

Customer Journey Mapping

- Not just your own department's touchpoint
- Reveals how your work connects to the whole
- Sets up Process Mapping next

Process Mapping Exercise

- Bottlenecks live at handoffs
- Invisible from any single vantage point
- Map the whole thing, not just your piece

Business Problem Analysis

- The first explanation is often wrong
- Systematic beats instinctive
- Verify against real data

Business Case Created

- Problem, solution, costs, benefits, risks
- More rigorous than an enthusiastic pitch
- The most demanding exercise in this stage

Cost-Benefit Analysis

- Real numbers, not just qualitative impressions
- Cheapest visible $\neq$ best value
- Backbone for a strong business case

Business Recommendation

- Analysis alone doesn't drive action
- State it clearly — don't just analyze
- Extends S14 and S15 into a real decision point

Market Research Exercise

- External reality, not internal assumption
- The best research produces a genuine surprise
- One source is never enough

Competitive Analysis

- Competitive assumptions go stale fast
- Genuinely current, not vague impressions
- Specific dimensions, not general vibes

Industry Analysis

- Beyond direct competitors
- Anticipate broader shifts
- Widest-scope research in the section

SESSION 3

Strategic & Reflective Business Thinking

FIRSTS S20-S25

Strategic Objective Analysis

- Well-executed $\neq$ strategically connected
- Map activities against real stated goals
- Often surfaces uncomfortable gaps

Executive Perspective Exercise

- Genuinely different priorities, not “more of the same”
- Sharpens analysis and leadership communication
- Difficulty here is itself useful information

Organizational Decision Analysis

- Real reasoning beats the simple, circulated story
- Ask someone with real context
- Builds genuine business judgment

Business Process Improvement

- Identifying isn't enough — implement it
- The most demanding FIRST in the stage
- Real follow-through required

Organizational Change Awareness

- Looks chaotic, usually isn't
- A genuine, deliberate underlying process
- Helps you navigate change, lead or affected

Business Acumen Reflection

- Across the whole stage, not just Session 3
- Name the uncomfortable gaps honestly
- An ongoing practice, not a finished checklist

Stage Fifteen, Complete

One strength, one gap — named honestly, out loud.